



The Voice That Carried

Student copy (project or hand out)

The following is a tribute to the singer Peabo Bryson, who died on June 2, 2026, at the age of seventy-five, written to mark a career that carried a voice from a South Carolina farm to the title songs of two animated films.

1 He learned to sing on a farm outside Greenville, on his grandfather's land in Mauldin, South Carolina, before anyone had a reason to listen. By fourteen he was on the road with a local revue, a boy carrying grown men's songs from one town to the next. Peabo Bryson, who died on June 2 at seventy-five, spent the next sixty years doing only that, carrying a song to people who needed it carried. And the voice that did the carrying never seemed to strain.

2 The songs people knew best were not all his own to begin with. He sang the title song to one animated film, and then to another, and for a generation of children the sound of a fairy tale became, without their ever learning his name, the sound of Peabo Bryson. He sang 'Beauty and the Beast' with Celine Dion. He sang 'A Whole New World' with Regina Belle, and it rose to the top of the pop chart in the winter of 1993. Each recording won a Grammy. Grown listeners had found him long before, through 'If Ever You're in My Arms Again' and a row of records before it. But it was the cartoons that slipped his voice into childhoods that did not know they were keeping it.

3 What set him apart was not range alone but restraint. He could have oversung any of it, and the era rewarded singers who did. Instead he trusted the melody and stayed out of its way, and the feeling arrived because he had not forced it. Twenty-one albums came and went across five decades. And he kept the same unhurried tone through all of them, the sound of a man who had decided long ago that a song does not need to shout to be believed.

4 Two years ago his hometown painted him onto a wall. In the fall of 2024, Greenville unveiled a mural of him at a park near where he had started, and he came home to stand in front of it. It was a small ceremony for a man who had filled large rooms. But it was the right size, somehow, for what the work had always been: a voice from one ordinary place, carried out to everywhere, and then welcomed back.

5 His family said his voice had been the soundtrack to some of life's most cherished moments. That is the kind of thing families say, and in this case it happens to be true; the songs are already loved by people who will never trace them back to a farm in Mauldin. He leaves a wife, two children, and grandchildren who will grow up inside the recordings. The voice is not going anywhere. It is in the films, and it will keep singing those fairy tales to children who are not yet born, which is a strange and ordinary kind of staying, the only kind a song was ever going to manage.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The writer's description of the mural unveiling as 'a small ceremony for a man who had filled large rooms' primarily serves to
 - A) honor the singer's reach by contrasting the modest occasion with the scale of his audience
 - B) suggest that his fame had faded by the end of his life
 - C) question whether the ceremony was worth his attention
 - D) fault his hometown for failing to hold a grander event
2. The relationship between the first paragraph and the second paragraph is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) describes his final concert, then explains why he stopped performing
 - B) praises his character, then concedes his weaknesses
 - C) places the singer in his obscure beginnings, then traces how his voice reached a vast audience
 - D) states the cause of his death, then lists every award he received

Discussion questions:

1. Again and again the writer sets something small against something large: a farm boy and a generation's childhoods, a small ceremony and large rooms. How does that recurring contrast shape the way the piece honors Bryson?
2. The writer claims Bryson's gift was restraint, that 'a song does not need to shout to be believed.' Where does the writing itself practice that same restraint, and what does it gain by doing so?

Writing prompt (Q2 rhetorical analysis):

Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to honor Peabo Bryson and to convey what made his voice and his manner distinctive. Consider how the writer's use of contrast, understatement, and concrete scenes from his life shapes the tribute.